COURSE OF TIME THERE WILL NOT BE SUCH A COMMUNITY KNOWN AS UNTOUCHABLES…"

Dakshayani's wedding to Dalit leader R Velayudhan was performed by a priest suffering from leprosy. Leprosy is an infectious disease that can be cured but can cause terrible disfigurement. Because of this, people who suffer from it have historically been ostracized.



At college, Dakshayani had to fight to be treated the same way as her classmates. An upper-caste teacher would not allow her to stand near enough to observe experiments for fear that her low-caste status would be 'polluting'.

A driven woman

Dakshayani admired Gandhi, and was also inspired by BR Ambedkar's anti-caste politics. She, too, became involved in campaigning against untouchability. At the age of thirty-four, she joined the Constituent Assembly as its youngest member. In the Assembly debates, she was vocal about the need to make untouchability illegal, arguing that it was the duty of the government to educate people and help abolish caste. In 1977, she founded the Mahila Jagriti Parishad to help Dalit women gain access to education and vocational training.